

Words 6,379

This paper was my first attempt to cross the boundary between clinical studies of the persisting violence that can follow violent deaths and the cycles of violence that can give rise to terrorism and war. In undertaking so ambitious a task I was helped by colleagues from the IWG (see below) who brainstormed together to create a useful model.

Some of the most harmful consequences of violence arise when a cycle of violence becomes established. In order to break cycles of violence we need to analyse the causes of such cycles. Yet violence evokes such strong emotions that it clouds our thinking and inhibits analytic thought. Indeed there is something ‘calculating’ about the very exercise in which we are engaged in this chapter. Like the anatomists who first dissected the human body, we need to find a way to touch the untouchable, to think clearly about the unthinkable, to inhibit our own revulsion from so dangerous a task.

Everyone has their own ‘solution’ to the problem of violence, which usually consists of identifying an enemy and defeating it. Another is the idea that the best way to break cycles of violence is to forbid violence, yet how can we enforce that prohibition if we are not willing to use violence itself? Police forces may need to use violence to apprehend a serial killer and ‘peace-keeping’ forces may need to use violence to protect themselves and to bring peace. Each discipline tends to develop its own model. Soldiers seek military solutions, clergy seek religious solutions, politicians seek political solutions and economists seek economic solutions. Some of these

solutions sometimes work, but none of them provides a comprehensive or integrated view, all are, to some extent, simplistic, they attempt a simple solution to complex problems. And, as we shall see, some simplistic models do more harm than good.

In this paper a model will be described which explains many, but not all, of the cycles of violence and illustrates how they can and have been broken. The examples are either derived from actual cases or from systematic research. They show that, although the causes may be complex they are often comprehensible and, although solutions may not be easy, they are often possible...

[Individual acts of violence rarely give rise to cycles of violence. It takes more than one person to perpetuate violence.]

Family and inter-personal level. Two or more individuals perpetuate or repeat acts of violence or abuse. These often involve circular ‘traps’ in which short-term relief from rising tension leads to perpetuation of conflict, e.g. marital tensions leading to alcohol abuse leading to repeated violence, or sado-masochistic sexual relationships. Although, at the outset, such cycles usually involve two individuals, others are soon drawn in to take sides.

Small Group/Community level. In many species cyclical changes in hormone levels trigger aggression against co specific at certain times each year, these lead to combats which come to an end as soon as one of the combatants submits or runs away, they seldom end fatally, e.g. rutting of stags in the Spring. In humans, it is reasonable to assume that similar hormonal changes predispose young people, particularly males, to engage in aggressive, challenging behaviour. Young females may encourage conflict by favouring winners.

A large difference between humans and other species is, of course, the opportunity to achieve status by other means than combat. Psychological battles... take the place of physical conflict, and the takeovers, feuds, and 'broken hearts' that result are seldom fatal.

Although few societies, in which a small scale of 'clan' or 'tribal' organisation is established, still exist, they were, over the long period of human evolution, the main unit of social organisation. Most societies lived in peace much of the time but, sooner or later conflicts over territory, food or available mates would arise. Repeated battles against neighbouring tribes met the purpose of extending or maintaining territory, they also widened the gene pool by enabling the victors to claim mates from another tribe. Young males, who did most of the fighting, were also rewarded with 'warrior' status. This enabled some tribes to survive while less martial tribes perished. Thus, in evolutionary terms, the cost to the community of the death of some warriors was balanced by the survival of the clan/tribe. ...

Large scale societies attempt to forbid or limit internecine feuds at the small group level with varying success. Within many societies subcultures see themselves as outside the law, 'outlaws' or gangs, which resemble the clan or tribe. They are particularly likely to arise when central government breaks down and/or the rewards of obedience to higher authority: wealth, jobs, security, etc. are denied e.g. in the poor areas of major cities with high levels of unemployment and little hope for the future. Gangs often use drugs and/or alcohol to reduce fear or increase excitement,

this in turn reduces inhibitions against violence, which is usually directed against other gangs or supposed enemies who may then become victims.

National level. Coups and revolutions occur when a powerful group within a large scale society attempts to wrest power from the leaders. If the conflict is not soon resolved cycles of violence may become established and we have a **Civil War**. Even when the conflict is resolved the seeds of future violence may have been sewn. Since the emergent power is likely to enact severe penalties against future revolt the defeated parties may become 'outlaws' as described above. For a revolution to become a civil war two things are needed: 1.) a balance of power between the contending parties such that neither can win a decisive victory, and 2.) the contending parties need to be unwilling or unable to find a way to share power.

International level. When a powerful large scale society attacks a weak or small-scale society the conflict is soon over although, as above, the seeds of future conflict may have been sewn and acts of resistance or 'terrorism' may continue. **Wars** arise when two or more powerful countries use violence against each other and, as in Civil Wars, the contenders cannot reach agreement to share power.

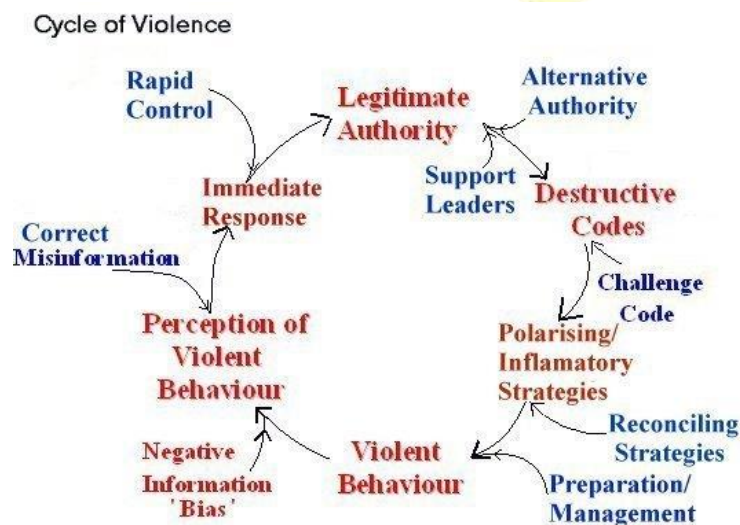
Although, at first glance, the differences between wars and smaller scales of conflict seem great, they become less so when we consider the important roles played by leaders and young males. At all levels of analysis, except the individual, it is a small number of leaders who have the power to stop the conflict or to allow it to continue. Likewise, at all levels of analysis, it is young males who do most of the fighting.

A Model of the Cycle which crosses levels of Social Unit.

With this in mind members of *the International Work Group on Death, Dying and Bereavement* (IWG) have developed a common model of cycles of violence capable of throwing light on the cycle at all levels above the individual. The model also suggests points at which intervention may break the cycle.

The IWG is a group of clinicians, researchers, and educators, from many countries, who develop research and practice dealing with death, dying and bereavement. Our work brings us face to face with the consequences of cycles of violence. It is this involvement that motivates IWG to find ways to understand and find solutions to the problem. A more detailed account of the model to be described here has been published in *Death Studies* (International Work Group on Death, Dying and Bereavement, 2005) ...

- Diagram -



Although the circumstances listed in the cycle tend to occur in sequence each influences all the others.

Violent behaviour seldom occurs out of the blue. It is usually preceded by a period of rising tension during which preventive intervention is possible.

Examples: Mothers who serially abuse their children are often themselves under stress. Only when she 'gets to the end of her tether' does a mother, who may genuinely love her child, suddenly find herself losing her temper and hitting the child against a wall. Social workers may be able to form a relationship of trust such that, whenever the mother becomes aware that her level of tension is rising, she will contact the social worker for immediate support and guidance.

At an international level the United Nations has appointed a Special Adviser on the Prevention of Genocide whose role is to ensure that the Security Council is informed fully about threats of genocide, which also represent threats to international peace and security.

Violence is most likely to lead to retaliation and the initiation of a cycle if it is excessive, disproportionate, cruel, or inhumane. When violence is threatened it may be possible to persuade or train those who are to carry it out to keep it to a minimum consistent with their aims. This is particularly the case when the violence is planned in advance. Rules of punishment and rules of engagement may authorise violence, but they also constitute opportunities for minimising it.

Examples The abolition of corporal punishment in schools.

Use of non-lethal methods of crowd-control (such as ‘foam baton rounds’ in place of conventional ammunition).

Those who carry out acts of violence need to monitor the consequences of their acts if they are to keep their violence to a minimum. This is easier in face-to-face combat than in conflicts that, with modern weapons, can be carried out without ever seeing the ‘enemy’. In these circumstances the temptation to ‘over kill’ in order to be sure of success regularly leads to death and injuries to non-combatants. Agreements can forbid or limit the use of weapons likely to give rise to excessive consequences.

Examples Legislation against the right of ordinary citizens to own or carry lethal weapons.

International agreements against development, ownership and use of weapons of mass destruction.

Perception of Violent Behaviour. It is the perception of an act that determines the response. Following acts of violence the magnitude of the impact and interpretation of the event is influenced by witnesses and how information is communicated to others. Thus, child abuse is often perpetuated because the abused child is afraid to reveal the abuse or because it is disbelieved. On the other hand some children exaggerate or imagine abuse that has not happened (False Memory Syndrome). This can lead to ‘witch hunts’ that drag on and lead to more injustice. Clearly accurate and impartial reporting and open-minded listening are essential if communication is to succeed and an appropriate response to be made. In psychiatric circles this is referred to as ‘reality testing’ and involves very much more than the communication of factual information.

Similar failure of communication can take place at other levels, as when newspaper reporters play down or, conversely, exaggerate the magnitude of an event and the dangers associated with it or when prejudice clouds our interpretation of the information we receive.

But accurate reporting does not necessarily solve the problem. While modern weaponry may make it hard for combatants to witness the consequences of their actions, modern media of communication have the opposite effect. On the 11th September 2001 hijacked airliners crashed into every home in the world in possession of a television set. Although the total number of deaths was about one hundredth of the number who died in the genocide in Rwanda, and no greater than the number who die on the roads every week in the United States, the perception of the outrage was much greater after 9/11 and its impact and consequences quite disproportionate. We cannot blame the mass media for showing these pictures but a great deal more could have been done to put them in perspective. In a few months the acts of a handful of religious extremists started a succession of wars, which are still not over.

Judges, whose experience of the adversarial system trains them to see both sides of every case, statisticians who are trained to weigh up the significance of large numbers, historians, who are trained to see events in their historical context, and psychotherapists, who are trained to take a family history and to hear what is not being said as well as what is, may be better placed than others to get such things in proportion. Journalists have so much influence that a high standard of training and performance should be required and monitored outside of political and other partisan influence. Schools should teach children how to read, understand and evaluate news.

Examples

[An account is given of the murder case described on p.xxx]

...In 1966 an avalanche, caused by the collapse of a spoil heap from the local coal mine in the village of Aberfan, resulted in the death of 116 children. In the weeks that followed, anger was spilling in all directions and three public meetings broke up in fistfights. Reporters from the *Merthyr Gazette* worked closely with the Disaster Response Team to scotch rumours and to provide distressed people with accurate information and opportunities to express their feelings in ways that would not add to their problems (e.g. in a poetry column). Subsequently the newspaper received a well-earned award for the quality of its support to the community. Many villagers attended the Board of Inquiry and found that the impartial examining of witnesses changed their perception of what had happened. Even when blame was attributed they could now acknowledge that those responsible were fallible human beings, not outright monsters (Parkes, 1976).

Immediate Responses to Violence. Fear and rage are natural responses to threat along with a tendency to seek out others in mutual defence. In the environment of evolution, such behaviour often enabled people to survive and even today this is sometimes the case. Unfortunately, misperception of the situation, pressure to take immediate action for fear of worse to come, and the escalation of fear which may infect crowds or other groups of people, may lead to intemperate responses that aggravate the situation and lead to a cycle of violence. Vilification and immediate

retaliatory acts against a supposed enemy, triumphalist behaviour by victors and attributions of martyrdom to victims may all contribute to escalate the violence.

It is of crucial importance that those responsible for keeping the peace take immediate action to advertise their presence and to take control of the situation, prevent further violence and give emotional support to those affected. This may include neighbours and others not directly under threat.

Examples. Murders are often carried out by family members. This sometimes makes investigating police officers suspicious and uncommunicative in their handling of bereaved families and aggravates bitterness and anger. In the UK special training is now provided to Police Family Liaison teams who are expected to provide emotional support at the same time as carrying out their investigative roles. One such team *[as described on pp. xxx-xxx]* worked closely with bereavement volunteers from Cruse Bereavement Care to provide ‘psychological first aid’ to traumatised families from the UK who were flown to New York in the wake of 9/11.

Legitimising Authorities. Cycles of violence seldom persist without the support of an authority or authorities who legitimise further violence. These may include parents, political leaders, religious leaders, military authorities, cult leaders, insurgent leaders and gang leaders. They may perpetuate the violence by direct command of military or other force, by exaggerating the danger in order to obtain popular support for retaliation, by reminding people of past wrongs and humiliations, and by

‘monsterising’ the ‘enemy’. These acts may be necessary responses to real dangers but they may also be unnecessary or disproportionate response to minimal dangers.

Unnecessary or disproportionate responses are likely to occur if the leader seeks to buttress an insecure power by uniting others behind him/her and against a common enemy. It then becomes unpatriotic to oppose the leader.

At times of violence parents and other leaders are often themselves traumatised and their ability to make wise decisions impaired. Some are more vulnerable than others, they may have personal problems, have suffered trauma in the past or lack emotional support. Only too often, those at the top of the tree are supposed to support people below them and to have no need for support for themselves. Having, in a crisis, adopted a particular stance it may then be difficult and/or politically disastrous for them to change their minds. It follows that every effort should be made to give psychological support to leaders following violent events and to dissuade them from drastic actions that may exacerbate the problems they face.

To varying degrees all leaders are subject to pressures and influence from power groups and from others. At times of violence such pressures are often in the direction of retaliation and leaders who temporise are seen as weak. Opposition groups may vie with the leader for public support for aggressive action each group adopting more extreme positions. Military leaders and political leaders who find their main support from the military are particularly likely to seek military solutions to their problems.

Other groups are likely to oppose violence and to offer alternatives to retaliation.

Indeed some constitute **alternative authorities** with the role of limiting the power of the parents or other leaders. These include legislative authorities such as social workers, religious leaders, judges, peace-keeping forces, arbitrators (who are authorised to make decisions about disputed issues) and mediators (who facilitate negotiation in the hope that contenders will reach agreement). All of these bodies can, at times, break cycles of violence.

Examples After the death of his wife, a caring but insecure father found it hard to cope with a nine-year-old son whose grief was reflected in rebellious behaviour. He exerted his authority by the only means he knew, beating the boy. His son responded by becoming increasingly bitter and by bullying other children. When a school teacher informed the social services the son was placed on the 'at risk' register and the father was induced, by the threat of judicial action, to accept the guidance of a social worker. He subsequently learned to obtain his son's cooperation by rewarding good behaviour in preference to coercion. The cycle of violence was broken, the relationship between son and father improved and the child's bullying ceased.

In Britain the monarch, unlike her Ministers, is relatively free of pressure from the electorate and often acts as a close adviser to her Prime Minister. In December 1861, at the height of the American Civil War, Britain's aged, gout-crippled, Prime Minister, Lord Palmerston, learned that a British ship, *the Trent*, had been intercepted by an American Union warship and two Confederate envoys, Mason and Slidell, taken into custody. Reaction, in the

Press, to this insult to the British flag was strong and, under pressure from his Foreign Secretary (John Russell), Palmerston showed the Queen a draft of a belligerent letter to the American Secretary of State. This would probably have led to extension of the war, with Britain taking the side of the Confederates and France drawn in to support the Union. Queen Victoria and Prince Albert, who was already suffering from the Typhoid Fever that would kill him two weeks later, persuaded Palmerston to accept a redraft of the letter, this provided the Americans with an opportunity to deny hostile intent and avoid an escalation of the war (Weintraub,1996).

Although the United Nations was criticised for its failure to prevent the genocide in Rwanda, the presence of small numbers of UN peace-keeping officers (*see p. xxx*), who moved rapidly to trouble spots in the wake of the genocide, probably helped to break the cycle of violence which had [*recurred*] over 25 years.

Acts of Legitimising Authorities, which may increase the risk of cycles of violence, include concealment of relevant information or plans, misrepresentation of dangers and adoption of double standards. Leaders who act covertly often encourage others to do the same, trust is undermined and all sides tend to expect the worst. Conversely open awareness reduces suspicion and the paranoid assumptions that encourage further violence.

Examples After their daughter died George and Mary each responded in their own ways, Mary by crying and seeking attention, and George by refusing to speak about his daughter, going to the pub and getting drunk. Mary accused George of not caring and George, who felt helpless and threatened by his wife's clinging, continued to distance himself from her. The affection that they had previously felt for each other seemed to dissolve. As time went by the tension between them increased and they took out their bitterness by abusing each other verbally and, at times, physically. Eventually Mary sought the help of a psychiatrist and her husband agreed to attend with her. The psychiatrist reminded them that anger is a natural reaction to bereavement and invited each of them to reveal how they felt about their daughter's death. Once George realised that he was not under attack or being blamed for his daughter's death he 'confessed' that he felt a failure as both husband and parent. He had backed away from his wife because he did not know how to help her. His frankness had an immediate effect on his wife who realised that, in his own way, her husband cared just as much as she.

Recently revealed documents about the Cuban Missile Crisis (Chang & Kornbluh, 2004) show how the danger of a nuclear war was greatly increased by the fact that both sides kept their intentions secret and deliberately set out to mislead the other. This led to each side assuming the worst and making plans for pre-emptive nuclear strikes against each other. Only when Kennedy and Khrushchev spoke directly and corrected these misperceptions of each other's intentions, could trust be established and a basis for agreement

reached. Even then both sides continued to conceal their negotiations from their followers in order to take credit for the outcome.

Destructive Codes. *[In subsequent research I have recognised that, although destructive codes undoubtedly contribute to cycles of violence, they are best considered as part of the context in which acts of violence take place and they then affect all of the choice points on the IWG's cycle].* Our brain is an organ one of whose main functions is to take in huge amounts of information and simplify it to the point where we can comprehend the world around us and cope with it successfully. One way of doing that is to adopt short-hand 'codes' to represent complex aspects of reality. Most of them we take for granted, they become axioms that form the basis of our assumptive worlds, the world that we assume to exist. Among these codes are assumptions about 'friends' and 'enemies', 'good' and 'bad', and 'right' and wrong'. 'Friends' we can trust, we can count on their loyalty at times of trouble, they will help to defend us from our enemies. On the whole we assume that friends are good and right. When they are not we forgive them their failings, we tend to idealise them. 'Enemies', on the other hand, are not to be trusted, they will harm our allies and us, they are bad and in the wrong. When they are not we ignore the discrepancy, we tend to monsterise them.

Although these codes are always simplifications of reality there is nothing wrong with having them, indeed we could not survive without them. Even so it is important to recognize that they can never be anything more than approximations to reality, the best we can manage. And there are times when they become destructive and contribute to cycles of violence. Cycles of violence are likely to persist if maintained

by the belief that my side is 'right', just and good, while the enemy is wrong, unjust and bad. Strangers and foreigners are often assumed to be dangerous and easily come to be seen as enemies. When we treat them as enemies it is not surprising if they do the same to us, thereby confirming and perpetuating the belief system (Hence the saw, 'Give a dog a bad name and it will bite you').

Codes of justice range from concepts of 'fairness' in personal relationships to more general belief in a rule of law based on human rights and assumed to be maintained by the ruling power. Codes of morality, distinguish good from bad. Codes of honour guide assessment of worth and esteem. Codes of propriety define what is proper, decent and correct. These codes, though all concerned with value, may conflict or compete with each other. Thus, the code of honour among young men may value bravery and pride above moral codes of gentleness and humanity. Indeed there are times when ruthlessness and cruelty to an enemy is seen as right by one side and monstrous by the other. At a family level codes which perpetuate cycles of violence include family myths such as, 'spare the rod and spoil the child', 'children are wicked by nature and the sin must be beaten out of them for the sake of their immortal souls'.

Cycles of violence are most likely to persist if buttressed by strongly held, inflexible, belief in codes that permit or encourage violence. Destructive codes include:

- Codes, such as 'An eye for an eye', which encourage retaliation,
- Codes which are exclusive, the only true faith, and denigrate other faiths,
- Codes which foster a belief in the superiority of a person or group, that makes them entitled to special privileges.

Codes which permit, reward or encourage cruelty, killing, suicide or martyrdom.

It follows that anything that persuades people to question, abandon or modify destructive codes will reduce the chances of violence becoming cyclical. Tolerance of people different from oneself may not come easily, but can be taught, so can respect for the positive codes of others, establishment of new codes that foster humility and tolerance, while discouraging extremism and violence. This is easier said than done for it is our codes that give us our identity. Question them and you devalue us. Even so some remarkable successes can be cited.

Examples Mahatma Ghandi developed his code of non-violence in South Africa. He wrote:

“It is necessary to revive the eternal law of answering anger by love and of violence by non-violence; ‘Hate the sin and not the sinner’ is a precept which, though easy enough to understand, is rarely practised, and that is why the poison of hatred spreads in the world... It is quite proper to resist and attack a system, but to resist and attack its author is tantamount to resisting and attacking oneself... It is the acid test of non-violence that, in a non-violent conflict, there is no rancour left behind, and in the end the enemies are converted into friends. That was my experience in South Africa, with General Smuts. He started with being my bitterest opponent and critic. Today he is my warmest friend.”

The application of Ghandi's policy of passive resistance to British domination of India became a non-destructive code that succeeded in producing major social change in India and eventual independence. There was very little violence on either side and the change has left a legacy of mutual respect between the two nations.

The Roman Emperor Constantine, in 313 CE, pronounced the 'Edict of Milan' declaring that 'complete toleration' should be given by the State to anyone who had 'given up his mind to the Christians' or any other cult. This brought an end to a long cycle of persecution of Christians (Johnson, 1976).

When codes are written down, or 'codified', they become more rigid, reduce ambiguity and simplify decision-making. Most religions codify both moral codes and codes of propriety. Believers then have a simple guide to what is right. Unfortunately different religions adopt different codes and even within the major religions there is considerable variation from fundamentalists to liberals in the flexibility with which the codes are applied. Codes of justice and human rights are codified as laws and these are usually assumed to apply to leaders as well as followers. This said, leaders often have the power to change laws. Cycles of violence may be created or broken by changing the law.

Examples. Marriage guidance counsellors often make use of a 'contract' which both sides can agree to and which, if kept, will reduce the chance of further conflict.

Most civilised countries now acknowledge such human rights as the right of people accused of an offence to hear the evidence against them and to be entitled to legal defence in a court of law. Even so, following 9/11, the British government introduced legislation allowing the indefinite detention, without such trial, of foreign nationals who are thought to support ‘terrorism’.

Although this attempt to deprive foreigners of their human rights was intended to break the cycle of terrorist violence, it may have had the opposite effect. By undermining Britain’s ethical position it supported the destructive code of some Moslems that Britain is a corrupt country ruled by Satan. The British legislation has recently been successfully challenged in the European court of human rights.

Polarising, Inflammatory Strategies. All of the foregoing factors influence the formation of strategies which sometimes inflame the situation and establish or perpetuate a cycle of violence. Perpetuation is particularly likely if the strategies result from an assumption that there is no alternative to a violent response. This is likely to be associated with scapegoating, *i.e.* focusing on a single assumed cause (e.g. Arabs, Jews, Religious Extremists) who can be defined as monsters or ‘enemies’ and defeated.

A cycle of violence is most likely to be established if, either

the balance of power is such that neither side can be defeated, or
having demonstrated their superior power by threatening or defeating the enemy the powerful then

- attempt to humiliate, punish or take revenge, or

- fail to deal with underlying causes of the conflict (e.g. injustice, poverty, or exploitation).

By depriving the weaker side of any chance of an acceptable existence hatred is generated, destructive codes established and the probability of future violence increased. Conversely, anything that allows all parties to live an acceptable existence, respects their world view, and attempts to put right the underlying causes of conflict, will reduce the chance of further conflict.

Example The film ‘One Flew over the Cuckoo’s Nest’ demonstrated how the abuse of power by the staff of a mental hospital could lead to resentment and eventual retaliation by the patients in their care. Although fictional, the film highlighted the conditions that led to the removal of physical methods of restraint, the unlocking of doors and the creation of ‘therapeutic communities’ in such institutions during the 1950s and ‘60s. Contrary to the expectations of older staff (who were locked into a destructive code), these changes led to a reduction in violence, improvement in symptoms and relationships between staff and patients, and eventually allowed many patients to leave mental hospitals and triggered systems of community care (Jones 1982).

After World War 1 the humiliation of Germany sewed the seeds of bitterness and, in the end, led to WW2. Two years after the end of WW2, on June 5, 1947, Secretary of State George C. Marshall spoke at Harvard University:

‘I need not tell you gentlemen that the world situation is very serious.
...the United States should do whatever it is able to do to assist in the
return of normal economic health in the world, without which there can

be no political stability and no assured peace. Our policy is directed, not against any country or doctrine, but against hunger, poverty, desperation, and chaos. Its purpose should be the revival of working economy in the world so as to permit the emergence of political and social conditions in which free institutions can exist’.

The Marshall Plan provided Germany with opportunities of economic recovery and broke the cycle of violence.

When violence starts it usually involves only a small number of people. They may be extremists or people who misperceive a situation as exceedingly dangerous. For the reasons given above, violence evokes violent responses and before long others are likely to be drawn in to take sides. This polarisation is usually a gradual process but it may be accelerated by the magnitude of the perceived threat and by group or individual pressures. Leaders who insist that ‘All who are not for us are against us’ are attempting to force people out of the middle ground. Consequently those who advocate peaceful alternatives may be framed as less committed to the group’s welfare, as appeasers, disloyal, naïve or cowards. Such behaviours increase polarisation and may foster cycles of violence. On the other hand those who resist such pressures or oppose extremism may help to break a cycle of violence. If polarisation is the centrifugal force driving people toward the poles, then centrism is the centripetal force that pulls them together. Those who insist on maintaining a middle ground can encourage centrism.

Examples In the case of George and Mary, cited above, their surviving children sided with Mary and George felt increasingly isolated and bitter as a

result. He had now lost, not only his daughter but his entire family. Their psychiatrist, on the other hand, refused to take sides or to judge either party. By holding to the middle ground he implied that it was possible for George and Mary to do the same. Instead of justifying their positions by attacking each other, they each tried to understand the other's point of view. Once the door to honest communication was open each parent realised the extent to which their grief had driven them to defend themselves and set up a cycle of distrust. They came to understand that they were needed by and had something to give to the other.

In May 1986 Nelson Mandela, who had been in prison for 23 years, received a visit from a group of Commonwealth leaders. His account of this meeting illustrates that it is possible for a leader, who had been seen as an extremist, to demonstrate a moderate or centrist position without betraying his cause:

‘I told them...that I was firmly committed to a non-racial society. I told them I believed in the Freedom Charter, that the Charter embodied principles of democracy and human rights, and that it was not a blueprint for socialism. I spoke of my concern that the white minority should feel a sense of security in any new South Africa. I told them I thought that many of our problems were a result of lack of communication between the government and the ANC [African National Congress], and that some of these could be resolved through actual talks. They questioned me extensively on the issue of violence, and while I was not yet willing to renounce violence, I affirmed in the

strongest possible terms that violence could never be the ultimate solution to the situation in South Africa.’ (Mandela, 1994)

The meeting marked a turning point in the negotiations that were to lead to the abandonment of *apartheid* in South Africa, Mandela’s emergence as the first black South African president and the first man to govern a democratic, multi-racial South African society.

Conclusions Some have claimed that it is the ‘animal’ nature of man that explains both the occurrence of violence and its perpetuation. Yet, as we have seen, aggression between non-human animals of the same species is rarely fatal. Furthermore all social animals share with human beings the tendency to make attachments to parents, children and, in most cases, peers. This inhibits aggression and facilitates social intercourse. Hence it can be argued that it is our ‘animal’ capacity for love that provides us with a natural tendency to abhor violence. Viewed in this way cycles of violence are an aberration. They are certainly not inevitable and should be preventable. Mankind is not doomed by his animal nature, we may treat strangers with suspicion but they need not remain strangers for long, indeed, as Ghandi maintained, it is natural to turn strangers, and even enemies, to friends.

Over the years we have developed systems of justice and social organisation that have reduced violence at family and community levels in many parts of the world. Where this is not the case this often reflects social injustice and ‘structural violence’ that leave the disempowered no perceived alternatives to violence. The whole-hearted adoption of international law and justice, the universal establishment of codes of

human rights and the fostering of ‘internationalism’ as an alternative to ‘nationalism’ would all tend to break the cycles of violence that destroy the peace of the world.

Scientific and technical developments have resulted in most of us living in a world that is largely man-made. Thanks to these developments we are now, in theory, capable of eliminating poverty and creating a society in which human rights can be guaranteed...

Given the global danger of cycles of violence in an age when weapons of mass destruction are available, it is surprising that similar attention has not been paid to the study and legislation that are necessary if we are to eliminate these cycles. Part of the difficulty may lie in the fact that there is no one scientific discipline that covers the field. The model developed here integrates knowledge from several different disciplines. This is a field in which psychologists, sociologists, political scientists, historians, economists, journalists, theologians, ethicists, military scholars and many others need to learn to work together. If they will take the trouble to reach out beyond the limits of their own restricted vision they may discover that cycles of violence are neither inevitable nor irreversible.

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